realist, while he sought peace he understood the importance of economic and military power.

Nehru was profoundly influenced by his mentor, Gandhi, and like him sought to change India and the world. After Gandhi's assassination within a year of Independence, Nehru saw himself as the father of his people and attempted to lay down the structure for modern India. He was fondly referred to as Chacha (Uncle) Nehru, a description he liked and tried to live up to by attempting to do many things and being many people at the same time. He wanted India to be economically self-sufficient, to raise its people from poverty and to emerge as a developed nation.

Nehru recognized India's diversity both as an opportunity and a threat. He feared fissiparous tendencies, primarily religious, and sought to keep India territorially unified and independent. He was a secularist who believed India would survive only if it embraced secularism and pluralism. Nehru believed wholeheartedly that a diverse and complex nation like India could best be kept together through voluntary union of ethnicities, religions, and racial and linguistic groups. For him, democracy was the way forward for India, and Nehru saw his role as that of educating both India's elite and masses on the merits of democracy.

Nehru also did not want India to become absorbed with itself to the point of becoming isolated from the world. Among his concerns was the prospect of a third world war resulting from contending military alliances, armed with nuclear weapons. He hoped to prevent a future war by preaching to the world's powers to move away from warmongering. Granville Austin has called Nehru 'an impatient democrat' and 'national nanny' and while both titles suit Nehru, the title 'international nanny' would be equally apt.[12] Nehru saw himself as a guide, a mentor not only to his own people but also to the rest of the world.

Nehru saw himself as a guide for India's new leadership and bureaucracy, many of whom had less global exposure than him. During the seventeen